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THE PORTFOLIOS ALLOCATED to the ministers of the NDA government, which returned for a third term after the General Elections, was proof, if proof was needed, that there wouldn't be much change.

Many of the top ministers retained their posts,

despite the BJP falling short of the majority mark in Parliament. This was especially true for the transport infrastructure space, but for a change in the aviation ministry.

Industry players and rating agencies are relieved. The infrastructure sector had been the crown jewel of the Narendra Modi-led government's last two terms—it had pressed the accelerator on a slew of road, rail, and aviation projects. And it's clear that the government intends to pick up from where it left off before the General Elections were called.

World-class infra-

structure development is a core component of the Modi government's 'Viksit Bharat 2047' (Developed India) vision. And the next five years, it is believed, will get the ball rolling on decisions related to capex allotment, fine-tuning of the blueprint, and incorporating technology to modernise the road, rail, and aviation sectors.

Of course, there may be a reassessment here or a tweak there because of the compulsions of a coalition government.

But industry stakeholders feel there will be more continuity than departures. The reason: Nitin Gadkari and Ashwini

Vaishnaw have retained the ministries they headed in the last term—road transport and railways, respectively. There is, of course, a change in the civil aviation ministry, which has been allocated to the 36-year-old Telugu Desam Party (TDP) Member of Parliament K. Rammohan Naidu, the youngest in the current Council of Ministers.

There could be further emphasis on multi-modal connectivity through PM Gati Shakti and the National Infrastructure Pipeline.

Ashish Modani, Senior Vice President and Co-Group Head-Corporate Ratings at ICRA Ltd, tells *BT* that continuity is the buzzword. "ICRA expects the new government to continue to maintain its thrust on the infrastructure sector, with continued strong outlay towards railways, roads, and water (drinking as well as sewage). There could be some re-prioritisation between various infra sub-segments to accommodate all the stakeholders."

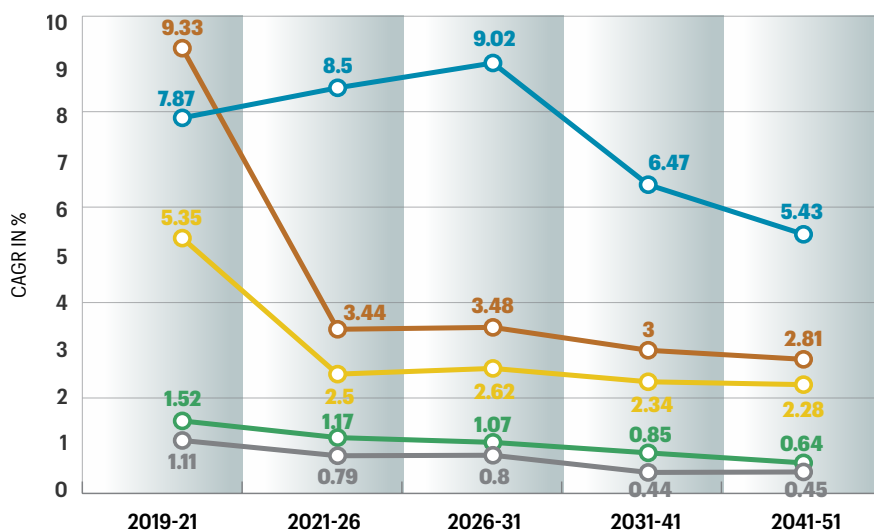
All eyes will be on the budgetary outlays and new announcements for these ministries in the Budget next month. Here is a look at the NDA's agenda in three sectors.

RAILWAYS

Modernisation tops the list of priorities at the 170-year-old Indian Railways, with capacity

ON TRACK

● Railway passenger growth is projected at a CAGR of over 2% till 2051 ● The maximum projected growth is in the AC category



○ PROJECTED POPULATION ○ LDAC ○ LDNA ○ SUBURBAN ○ OVERALL
LDAC LONG DISTANCE AC PASSENGERS LDNA LONG DISTANCE NON-AC PASSENGERS SOURCE NATIONAL RAIL PLAN